the same thing and, even when we are troubled about the variability of our identity, reflection suggests a persisting single subject that asks the questions. Moreover, we know that our previous actions and experiences don't just linger in the memory but often have a real impact on our present circumstances. And the way we live now affects our future. Buddhism does not deny that all this is real human experience. But it is just human convention. The absolute truth is that objective reality is an impersonal flux of instants. Some of the basic constituents of existence automatically form streams of experience that are interpreted as continuous selves The constituents behave in such a way that individuals impose cause–effect relations upon successive occurrences that we interpret as our decisions, actions and their consequences. But the truth is that reality is basically a field of mental and material particles. What is really happening is independent of human intellect and will, which are not fundamental to the process.

Advaita Vedanta makes a similar distinction between absolute and conventional reality. But according to them there is a single absolute reality beyond all oppositions, which is static, featureless consciousness. Upon it we superimpose the differentiated conventional world of individual centres of awareness and agency, and objects.

Parartha-anumana (inference for the sake of other people): this is a fully elaborated sequence of statements that follow one another logically. It is used for proving a point in public debate. By contrast, there is *svartha-anumana* (inference for oneself) which just involves one's thoughts and does not make public assertions. The form is simpler: 'There is smoke on the mountain and smoke is always accompanied by fire.'

See ***Anumana***